Empowering Women in SMEs

Agenda

Learning Objectives:

By the end of this lecture, students will:

•Understand the role of women in SMEs.

•Identify key challenges faced by women entrepreneurs.

•Explore strategic solutions to empower women in SMEs.

•Evaluate the socioeconomic impact of women-led businesses.

•Discuss future career opportunities for women in entrepreneurship.

The Power of Women

Defining the role of women in SMEs

- **Women Entrepreneurs (WE)** refer to women who initiate, organize, manage, and grow a business venture. They play a significant role in economic development by creating jobs, fostering innovation, and contributing to various industries.
- Women play a transformative role in SMEs, driving economic progress, innovation, and social impact. Addressing the challenges they face through financial support, policy reforms, and digital empowerment will unlock their full potential and lead to more inclusive economic growth.

Key Challenges Faced by Women in SMEs

- **Financial Barriers:** Limited access to funding and investment.
- **Legal and Regulatory Hurdles:** Issues with business registration and ownership rights.
- **Cultural and Social Norms:** Gender bias, societal expectations, and work-life balance.
- **Limited Access to Markets:** Difficulty in expanding businesses and reaching customers.
- **Skill Development Gaps:** Lack of training in financial management, marketing, and technology.

Strategic Solutions to Empower Women in SMEs

- **Access to Finance:** Microloans, government grants, and women-focused investment programs.
- **Policy Reforms:** Government initiatives supporting women entrepreneurs.
- **Networking and Mentorship:** Women business networks and leadership training programs.
- **Education and Skill Development:** Business training, digital literacy, and financial management programs.
- **Technology and Innovation:** Use of e-commerce and digital platforms to expand business reach.

Evaluating Socioeconomic Impacts of Women in SMEs

- Economic Growth: Contribution to GDP and job creation.
- Poverty Reduction: Financial independence leading to improved living standards.
- Social Development: Increased investment in health, education, and community development.
- Diversity and Innovation: How women-led SMEs drive innovation and inclusivity.

Advancing Future Career Opportunities for Women

- By emerging fields for women entrepreneurs (e-commerce, fintech, social enterprises).
- Promoting the role of digital transformation in creating new opportunities.
- Government and private sector support in fostering female entrepreneurship.
- Encouraging leadership roles for women in business and management

Advancing Future Career Opportunities for Women

- E-commerce & Digital Platforms – Selling products/services online.
- Social Enterprises – Businesses addressing social issues.
- Fintech & Microfinance – Expanding financial inclusion.
- Leadership Roles – Women in executive and managerial positions.
- STEM-based Entrepreneurship – Encouraging women in tech and innovation sectors.

Grameen Bank Promoting Women Employment under Social Entrepreneurship Model in Bangladesh

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Thank you!